

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In Geek-key, learn about fantastic magical schools and where to find them. Then head on over to DGT to check out some cool tech and catch up on what we've been watching. Finally, rewind with some memes in BackByte



The RSA Hack

The riveting inside story of the RSA Hack, that can finally be told after the expiry of non disclosure agreement. This sophisticated hack stealing the seed keys from a secure digital warehouse of a major cybersecurity company was an early form of the supply chain attack that permanently changed the cybersecurity landscape.
<http://dgit.in/rsah>

WHAT'S NEW

Bug Brain Soup

Researchers had this problem quantifying the neurons in invertebrate brains, so they came up with the innovative idea of scooping out the brains from a bunch of critters, mashing them together, and then quantifying the neurons in the bug brain soup. This is the cutting edge technique used by entomologists to putting an approximate number on how many brain cells are there in the heads of several species of bees, ants and wasps. The study had some surprising results, including that ants had less of a brain than most scientists anticipated, and that some bee species packed in more neurons in a given volume than even birds. Researchers need to quantify the neural matter in the brain to better understand



and model their behavior and cognition, including those of creatures that are only known from the fossil record. There are very few direct measurements available for the neural densities of any species, including humans. Historically, this has been because estimating the neural density is a painstaking and time consuming process. A tiny species known as the fairy wasp, which is only as long as three human hairs placed side by side, has a brain of 10,000 neurons and has possibly the smallest insect brain known.

Forget autonomous or flying cars, invest in buses

Tesla itself has admitted that its fully self driving claim may not be feasible to realise, and in the process of rolling out the technology, the industry has truly discovered what a difficult job it is. The techno futuristic utopia envisioned by a string of urban mobility startups that include fleets of autonomous cars available as a subscription service or the ability to rent out an autonomous vehicle that you own as a taxi for when it



is not being used is seriously being rethought. Both Uber and Lyft have recently sold their autonomous vehicle divisions, and Waymo had a leadership reshuffle. The thing is, in the long term, both humanity and the

planet may just be better off by reducing the number of vehicles on the road, and instead look towards more sustainable ways of moving more people around, such the hyperloop, or the regular old technology known as buses. The better option right now is for policy decisions that just reduce the number of cars on the road. The world is just not ready for autonomous cars yet, and may never be.

<http://dgit.in/autonom>



Long March falling

A chinese heavy lift rocket, Long March 5B is close to the point of deorbiting, and the problematic thing is that nobody really knows when and where this 23 ton of space debris will hit the Earth. There is obviously a 70 percent chance that it will hit some water body.
<http://dgit.in/lm5bdeb>



Faceswap celeb

A beautiful, attractive, young female Japanese biker who accumulated a lot of followers on social media by posting pictures of herself touring across Japan turned out to be a middle aged man who was spotted by some sharp followers in a sus reflection on one of the photos.
<http://dgit.in/dadfish>



Animals laugh too

Researchers investigating a range of playful vocalisations in a range of animals have come to the conclusion that animals like to laugh too, and that might be signalling others in the group to join in the fun that they are indulging in when they laugh, just like humans do.
<http://dgit.in/slaugh>